

Is It a Person or a Computer? Experts Share Tips on Young Kids and AI

From: PBS NewsHour Mined: 2026-10-06 5 min read

Young children are meeting **artificial intelligence**, or AI, in their everyday lives. They hear **smart assistants** like Amazon's Alexa or Apple's Siri at home, and they may see AI-made videos on YouTube. Experts say the years before age 8 are an important time to help kids understand what AI is and what it is not.

Lauren Girouard, a researcher at the Harvard Graduate School of Education and the University of Michigan, studies how children 12 and under use digital information. She said **preschoolers** can already learn from technology. She added that AI learning **tutors** can be valuable, but researchers are still learning how kids interact with the AI tools many families have used at home since ChatGPT arrived at the end of 2022.

Jennifer Katzenstein of Johns Hopkins All Children's Hospital suggested that when a smart speaker answers, parents can explain, "That's the computer answering." She also said kids can ask another adult what they think, so they learn the difference between a human answer and a computer answer.

Dr. Jenny Radesky of the University of Michigan said little kids are "much more magical thinkers." Until her son was 7, he thought Siri was a real woman living in California. She suggested reminding kids that a machine has never felt sad and does not have a body. She also suggested giving a smart speaker a **wake word** that is not a human name, such as "Computer."

Dr. Molly O'Shea, a **pediatrician**, said parents can also skip smart devices. When a child asks a question the parent cannot answer, they can guess and solve the problem out loud together.

Common Sense Media, a group that studies the risks of tech products, has urged parents to keep AI toys away from children 5 and younger.

Word Treasure

artificial intelligence -- Artificial intelligence is computer technology that can do tasks that usually need human thinking, like answering questions.

smart assistants -- Smart assistants are voice programs, like Alexa or Siri, that answer questions and follow spoken commands.

preschoolers -- Preschoolers are young children, usually ages 3 to 5, who are not yet in kindergarten.

tutors -- Tutors are helpers who teach one student or a small group, and some are now computer programs.

wake word -- A wake word is the word you say to make a smart speaker start listening.

pediatrician -- A pediatrician is a doctor who takes care of children.

Background you need

Artificial intelligence, or AI, is computer technology that can answer questions, tell stories or make content in ways that can seem human.

Smart assistants like Alexa and Siri listen for a wake word and then answer out loud, which is why young children may think a real person is talking.

Many families have used personal AI tools at home since ChatGPT arrived at the end of 2022, so researchers are still studying how these tools affect young kids.

Experts focus on the years before age 8 because a lot of important brain development happens then.

Break it down

LEAD: Young children are meeting AI through smart assistants and AI-made videos

KEY POINT: Experts say the years before age 8 are key for learning what AI is and is not

+ - WHO: Lauren Girouard, Jennifer Katzenstein, Dr. Jenny Radesky, Dr. Molly O'Shea

+ - WHERE: At home, through smart speakers and YouTube

EVIDENCE: Preschoolers can learn from technology; Radesky's son thought Siri was a real woman

TIPS: Say "That's the computer answering," ask another adult, use a non-human wake word, or skip smart devices

OPEN QUESTION: Researchers are still learning how at-home AI affects young children

Why it matters

As AI tools become part of everyday family life, helping young children tell the difference between people and machines may shape how they trust and learn from technology.

Test what you remember

1. Before what age do experts say is an important time to help kids understand AI?
 - (A) Age 12
 - (B) Age 16
 - (C) Age 8
 - (D) Age 3
2. What did Jennifer Katzenstein suggest parents say when a smart speaker answers?
 - (A) "That's the computer answering."
 - (B) "Turn it off now."
 - (C) "Say thank you to the lady."
 - (D) "Ask it again later."
3. What did Dr. Jenny Radesky's son believe about Siri until he was 7?
 - (A) That it was his teacher
 - (B) That it was a cartoon character
 - (C) That it was a robot in his house
 - (D) That it was a real woman living in California
4. Which wake word did the article give as an example of one that is not a human name?
 - (A) Helper
 - (B) Computer
 - (C) Buddy
 - (D) Hello
5. What can parents do instead of using smart devices, according to Dr. Molly O'Shea?
 - (A) Guess and solve the problem out loud with the child
 - (B) Ask a smart speaker
 - (C) Look it up on YouTube
 - (D) Buy an AI toy
6. What has Common Sense Media urged parents to do?
 - (A) Keep AI toys away from children 5 and younger
 - (B) Let kids use ChatGPT alone
 - (C) Buy more smart speakers
 - (D) Rename every toy

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: A 3: D 4: B 5: A 6: A

Questions to think about

1. **Researcher Lauren Girouard:** AI learning tutors can be valuable, but how kids interact with personal at-home AI is still being studied.
2. **Dr. Jenny Radesky:** Little kids are magical thinkers, so parents should explain in concrete terms that AI is not human.
3. **Dr. Molly O'Shea:** Parents can skip smart devices and solve questions out loud together with their children.
4. **Common Sense Media:** Parents should keep AI toys away from children 5 and younger.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):